THEATRE 3055: STAGE LIGHTING DESIGN 1

SYLLABUS

Class Meets: Wednesday & Friday 9:05am – 11:00am.
In person sessions will take place in the Acting Studio. (THTR C240)
Remote session will be conducted via Zoom.

Instructor: **Jonathan Spencer, MFA**
Email: J.Spencer@Colorado.edu
Office: C1B80 University Theater Building
Office Hours: Wednesday 11:00am – 1:00pm, or by appointment

Weeks listed in the schedule as "JS Out" we can connect via e-mail and scheduled phone/zoom appointments.

Emails: Please include your name and course # in all communications. I will do my best to respond promptly, but feel free to follow up if you haven't heard back in a while—I'll appreciate the reminder! Replies on evenings, weekends, or holidays are not guaranteed and are at the instructor's discretion, so avoid relying on last-minute emails.

Welcome!

Welcome to Theater 3055, an exploration into the process, creation, observation, and communication of lighting design for performance. Lighting design is a compelling and dynamic aspect of theater production—and I fully expect this class to be fun, hands-on, and an exciting introduction to the field!

Course Objectives

This course introduces the foundational principles, workflow, vocabulary, equipment, and tools used by theatrical lighting designers. While our focus is theater, many of the skills you'll learn also apply to fields like architectural lighting design, engineering, environmental design, interior design, and game design.

By the end of the semester, you will be able to:

- Read and interpret architectural-style drafting plates for theatrical lighting systems and create beginner-level versions using **Vectorworks Spotlight** drafting software.
- Hang, circuit, patch, and focus common conventional stage lighting fixtures.
- Wire a lightbulb and common stage plugs, with an understanding of **basic electrical safety**.
- Program lighting cues using **Electronic Theater Controls (ETC) EOS** lighting consoles.
- Use **lighting color theory** to analyze and enhance objects and garments.
- Develop and communicate **lighting design concepts** with intention and creativity—whether you're designing for a play, musical, sculpture, or environment.

Skills for Success

To thrive in this course, the following skills and attitudes are helpful:

- A curiosity for technology and a willingness to learn new software.
- Comfort working with your hands and interacting with physical equipment.
- Basic understanding of geometry, angles, proportion, and spatial awareness.
- Most importantly: a **creative mindset**, an openness to experimentation, and the resilience to engage in **trial and error**. Learning a new artform is less about inherent talent and more about showing up, being curious, and trying again.

What You'll Be Asked to Do

Throughout the course, you may be expected to:

- Use basic hand tools.
- Work with electricity.
- Climb ladders and work at height.
- Work in the dark with fellow classmates

Please **dress appropriately** and wear closed-toe shoes. If you are uncomfortable with heights, please speak with the instructor privately—your limits will always be respected. Our goal is to create a safe and supportive environment where you might even surprise yourself with what you're capable of!

Required Equipment

1. **Warm white flashlight** (We'll test phone flashlights together to see if they meet this need.)
2. **Laptop** capable of running class-related software. If you do not have access, swipe access to the Theatre Department computer lab can be provided.
3. **Scroll-wheel / 3-button mouse** – essential for drafting software; trackpads are not sufficient.

A **Rosco Lighting Gel Book** will be assigned to you for use during the semester. These must be returned in good condition. Failure to return your gel book may delay your final grade or affect your participation score.

Other necessary equipment will be provided during class as needed.

Texts & Materials

There are **no required textbooks**. Selected PDFs, videos, and other materials will be provided throughout the semester to support your learning.

Course Schedule

Refer to the **Course Schedule** document for a detailed list of classes, assignments, and deadlines. This schedule is subject to change to better fit the pace of the class or in response to changing campus conditions. Any adjustments will be communicated well in advance.

Mandatory Attendance Events

You are required to attend **two live Theatre and Dance performances** outside of regular class hours.

- At least **one** must be a **mainstage production** presented by the Theatre Department.
- Ticket and student discount information will be provided.

Missing one event will result in a **1/3 letter grade deduction** (e.g., a B- becomes a C+).
Missing both events results in a **2/3 grade deduction** (e.g., a B- becomes a C).

After Attendance:

Within **24 hours** of attending a performance, you must upload a brief reflection to Canvas, including:

- Date and time attended
- A short description of what you observed
- Your impressions and any questions or thoughts the lighting design provoked

Example:

"I attended the Wednesday evening performance of *[Show Title]* in the Irey Theatre. I found the use of shadows in the final scene very effective. It made me think about how contrast can support storytelling. I'm curious about how the designer achieved that effect."

You'll also be expected to participate in class discussions about these performances. The goal is to spark curiosity and conversation—**not just check a box**. These events are intended to be enjoyable, so gather some classmates and go see some art together!

Course Grading:

ITEM	POINTS	NOTES
DESIGNER BIO PRESENTATION	40	
LIGHTING JOURNAL	100	
QUIZ # 1	50	
QUIZ # 2	60	
LABS PREP & EXECUTION	500	Fixtures, Control, Motivated, Rhythm Cue, Color, Dance, Vectorworks, Final Cue
FINAL EXAM	150	
PARTICIPATION	100	

Grades:

94 – 100%	A
90 – 93%	A-
87 – 89%	B+
83 – 86%	B
80 – 82%	B-
77 – 79%	C+
73 – 76%	C
70 – 72%	C-
67 – 69%	D+
63 – 66%	D
60 – 62%	D-
59% or below	F

Quizzes

There will be **two quizzes** during the semester. These will be administered **in person, synchronously**, using the Canvas platform.

- You **must be physically present** in class to take the quiz—no remote participation is allowed.
- Quizzes are **closed book**, but students may bring **one 8.5" x 11" single-sided page of handwritten notes**.
- The use of **any other tools or resources** (including digital devices, internet searches, shared documents, etc.) is **prohibited**, unless **explicitly approved by the instructor in advance**.

Expectations will be clearly outlined ahead of time, and academic integrity is expected at all times.

Final Exam

The **final exam** will be administered **remotely via Canvas** and will follow the same rules as the quizzes.

- You may use **one 8.5" x 11" single-sided page of handwritten notes**.
- Adherence to the **university's Honor Code** is essential.
- Any suspicion of unauthorized resource use will be investigated and may result in disciplinary action.

Lighting Journal

The **Lighting Journal** is a creative, reflective, and ongoing assignment designed to increase your awareness of light in your everyday life.

- You will complete **one journal entry per week** for the **first 12 weeks** of the semester.
- Entries are due **every Sunday by 11:59 PM** to receive credit for that week.
- **Late submissions will not be accepted.**
- You are expected to work on this journal **incrementally**, not all at once at the end of the term.

This journal may come up in class discussions, and you may be asked to share a recent observation at any time—so stay engaged with the process.

Other Assignments

All assignments will be evaluated according to criteria shared in class discussions and assignment-specific rubrics. General grading guidelines include the following four areas:

Communication

Lighting designers must communicate their ideas clearly and persuasively. This course emphasizes both **written** and **spoken** communication:

- Written work should be carefully **edited and proofread**.
- Presentations should be **well-prepared and practiced**.

Collaboration

Theater is a collaborative art form. You must:

- Work effectively with classmates.
- Practice both **constructive criticism** and **active listening**.
- Foster a positive, respectful, and engaged collaborative spirit during class, lab, and group projects.

Design

Design sensibilities take time to develop. While this course will assess your current design thinking, the most important advice is:

Be bold, brave, and confident.
Good design is often hindered by fear—take creative risks!

Technology

Lighting design is inseparable from technology. Part of your grade will reflect your:

- Comfort and competence with tools and equipment.
- Willingness to troubleshoot and ask questions.
- Skill growth over time with the class's core technologies.

Attendance

Consistent attendance is essential.

This course is **experiential** and **cumulative**, built around hands-on work, discussion, and collaboration. Missing class means missing hours of shared physical work, creative exploration, and dialogue that **cannot be easily replicated or summarized.**

- If you miss a **lab**, makeup opportunities **may not be possible** due to shared spaces and limited access to equipment.
- Please plan to attend **every class session** and **arrive on time**.
- If you know in advance that you'll miss class, speak with the instructor as early as possible.

Participation

Participation is a significant component of your grade. To earn full credit, students must:

- Arrive **on time**
- Be **alert and focused**
- Come **prepared** with materials
- Assist in the **physical labor** of the class (light hanging, cabling, setup, etc.)
- Contribute meaningfully to **discussions**

"Alert" includes being actively engaged—making eye contact, asking questions, and participating in group work.

In **remote sessions**, please present yourself professionally and engage as you would in person.

Deadlines

In the world of theatrical production, **deadlines are sacred**—the show must go on!

- **Plan ahead.** Test your tech. Start assignments early.
- Work is due **by the start of class** on the date listed in the Course Schedule.
- **Late assignments** will be penalized **5% per day** for up to **7 days**, to a maximum of **35% deduction**.
- Work more than **14 days late** will **not** be accepted.
- **No work** will be accepted **after the last day of classes**, unless explicitly stated in the assignment.

Sending a last-minute email with a question about the assignment **does not** excuse a late submission.

Extra Credit

There are **no extra credit opportunities** in this course.

Lighting design is a cumulative skill. Begin engaging early and consistently. Falling behind early in the semester will make recovery difficult. The best strategy for success is to:

- Start your work early
- Ask for help when needed
- Manage your time effectively

There will be **no "points back" later in the semester**, so stay on top of your work from the start!

Syllabus Statements

Honor Code

All students enrolled in a University of Colorado Boulder course are responsible for knowing and adhering to the Honor Code. Violations of the Honor Code may include but are not limited to: plagiarism (including use of paper writing services or technology [such as essay bots]), cheating, fabrication, lying, bribery, threat, unauthorized access to academic materials, clicker fraud, submitting the same or similar work in more than one course without permission from all course instructors involved, and aiding academic dishonesty. Understanding the course's syllabus is a vital part of adhering to the Honor Code.

All incidents of academic misconduct will be reported to Student Conduct & Conflict Resolution: StudentConduct@colorado.edu. Students found responsible for violating the Honor Code will be assigned resolution outcomes from Student Conduct & Conflict Resolution and will be subject to academic sanctions from the faculty member. Visit Honor Code for more information on the academic integrity policy.

Accommodation for Disabilities, Temporary Medical Conditions, and Medical Isolation

If you qualify for accommodations because of a disability, please submit your accommodation letter from Disability Services to your faculty member in a timely manner so that your needs can be addressed. Disability Services determines accommodations based on documented disabilities in the academic environment. Information on requesting accommodations is located on the Disability Services website. Contact Disability Services at 303-492-8671 or DSinfo@colorado.edu for further assistance. If you have a temporary medical condition, see Temporary Medical Conditions on the Disability Services website.

If you have a temporary illness, injury or required medical isolation for which you require adjustment, alert the instructor by email as soon as possible.

Accommodation for Religious Obligations

Instructional faculty members must make every reasonable effort to accommodate all students who have conflicts with scheduled exams, assignment deadlines or required attendance due to a religious observance. Whenever possible, students must notify the instructional faculty member at least two weeks in advance of the expected exam, assignment deadline, or attendance conflict to request an accommodation for religious observance. If the start date of the course is less than two weeks before the date of requested accommodation, students must notify the instructional faculty member on the start date of the course. See the Student Academic Accommodations for Religious Observances Policy for more information.

In this class, please alert the instructor of the need for an accommodation within the first two weeks of the semester.

Student Names and Pronouns

CU Boulder recognizes that students' legal information does not always align with how they identify. If you wish to have a name other than your legal name appear on your instructors' class rosters and in Canvas, or if you wish to choose pronouns to appear on your instructors' class rosters and in Canvas, visit the Registrar's website for instructions on how to change your personal information in university systems.

Classroom Behavior

Students and faculty are responsible for maintaining an appropriate learning environment in all instructional settings, whether in person, remote, or online. Failure to adhere to such behavioral standards may be subject to

discipline. Professional courtesy and sensitivity are especially important with respect to individuals and topics dealing with race, color, national origin, sex, pregnancy, age, disability, creed, religion, sexual orientation, gender identity, gender expression, veteran status, marital status, political affiliation, or political philosophy.

Additional classroom behavior information

- Student Classroom and Course-Related Behavior Policy.
- Student Code of Conduct.
- Office of Institutional Equity and Compliance.

Sexual Misconduct, Discrimination, Harassment and/or Related Retaliation

CU Boulder is committed to fostering a productive and welcoming learning, working, and living environment. University policy prohibits protected-class discrimination and harassment, sexual misconduct (harassment, exploitation, and assault), intimate partner abuse (dating or domestic violence), stalking, and related retaliation by or against members of our community on- or off-campus. Denial of an approved accommodation for disability, religious observance, or pregnancy or pregnancy related medical conditions may be discriminatory.

The Office of Institutional Equity and Compliance (OIEC) addresses these concerns, and individuals who have been subjected to misconduct can contact OIEC at 303-492-2127 or email OIEC@colorado.edu. Information about university policies, OIEC reporting options, and OIEC support resources including confidential services can be found on the OIEC website.

Faculty and graduate instructors are required to inform OIEC when someone discloses misconduct regardless of when or where it occurred. This is to ensure that those impacted receive outreach from OIEC about resolution options and support resources. To learn more about reporting and support options for a variety of concerns, visit the Don't Ignore It page.

Mental Health and Wellness

The University of Colorado Boulder is committed to supporting students' mental health and overall wellbeing. If personal, academic, or emotional challenges are affecting your wellbeing or success, Counseling and Psychiatric Services (CAPS), is here to help. CAPS offers counseling, referrals, psychiatric care, crisis support, and much more. Visit CAPS in the C4C, or call (303) 492-2277, 24/7.

Acceptable Use of AI in This Class

AI tools may be used in this course **only for visual research and inspiration**. For example, you may use AI-generated images to explore visual ideas, references, atmospheres, color, composition, or other aspects of your lighting research.

AI may not be used to generate, draft, rewrite, summarize, or provide "background research" for any written work submitted for this course. This includes using AI to generate ideas or language that you subsequently incorporate into your own writing.

AI should not be used to summarize, interpret, analyze, or provide background information about any of the plays read in this course. Your understanding of the plays, characters, themes, circumstances, and dramatic structure must come from your own reading and analysis.

Your written descriptions of design intentions must also be entirely your own ideas and your own words. Do not use AI to formulate, develop, or articulate your design intentions, even if you substantially edit the resulting text.

Your analysis must be your own. Your design thinking, interpretation, observations, and conclusions must come from you.

When in doubt, ask before using an AI tool. The goal is for your submitted work to demonstrate your thinking, your analysis, your design choices, and your voice.